

THE CONFLUENCE
Work on at a VIP ghat at the Sangam

VIYUM A

UTTAR PRADESH

A MAHA KUMBH CHALLENGE

By Ashish Misra

The Yogi Adityanath government in Uttar Pradesh, which came in for praise for the 2019 Kumbh arrangements in Prayagraj, is looking for a repeat with the once-in-12-years Maha Kumbh starting on January 13, 2025. Some 430 projects worth Rs 8,000 crore had been sanctioned in Prayagraj for the "world's largest religious spectacle" with its akhada processions and sadhus and, if last time's numbers hold, some 250 million devotees in attendance and taking the holy dip at the Sangam. The target was to complete all the works by December-end, but with just eight weeks left for the Kumbh, some 150-odd projects are running behind schedule. Projects in the 'red zone' include 38 of the Prayagraj Development Authority (PDA), 66 of the irrigation department and 18 of the PWD, among others.

A livid Yogi, who visited Prayagraj in early October, has read the riot act to the officials. Sixteen engineers have been issued show cause notices for negligence and irregularities. Prominent social activist Ajit Singh says, "The government knew the Kumbh dates, so they should have planned accordingly. Now they are hurrying up the work and there is no guarantee of quality. This has all the makings of a huge scam in the Maha Kumbh."

A textbook case of the delays is the 30 pontoon bridges being built at the Sangam site at a cost of Rs 100 crore. The contract for supplying 9,300 cubic metres of Sal wood sleepers had been given to five timber firms in Raipur, Chhattisgarh, who were supposed to deliver it by November 5. But till date not even 50 per cent of the sleepers have arrived.

Yogi has now brought back IAS officer Vijay Kiran Anand, the Mela officer from 2019, and entrusted him with the task of putting some speed into proceedings. Some 20 other top bureaucrats and eight state ministers have also been roped in to monitor the daily progress of projects. One thing is for sure—not all the projects will see fruition by the deadline. Some of the big-ticket projects facing delays include a six-lane bridge on the Ganga river from Phaphamau to Civil Lines, the new terminal building at Prayagraj airport, building of three concrete ghats at the Sangam, the redevelopment of the Civil Lines and Zero Road bus stations in Prayagraj, the Rs 1,000 crore expansion of the Prayagraj railway terminus, and the 29-km-long ring road from Palpur to Sahason bypass on the Prayagraj-Rewa highway. Prayagraj was also among the select ones to be part of the Smart City Mission in 2017; 119 development works worth Rs 800 crore related to this are also hanging fire. According to the original plan, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is to inaugurate 150 projects worth Rs 3,500 crore in mid-December. It remains to be seen whether Yogi's men can whip things into some sort of readiness by then. ■

> **"All the Maha Kumbh work has to be done by December 10. Any delay will cost us"**
>
> **–Yogi Adityanath**
> *Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh*



ANDHRA PRADESH

AMARAV

By Amarnath K. Menon

In October 2015, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had laid the foundation stone for the greenfield Andhra Pradesh capital project, Amaravati. Now, almost nine years to the day, Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu has announced that he will be restarting work on his dream project that had been put on ice during the Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy regime (2019-24).

"Destiny has found its course. After five years of neglect and crushed hopes, Amaravati rises again. Our people's capital will now be built...the work restarts today, Onward and Upward," declared Naidu, taking to social media platform X to announce that construction had resumed on the eight-storied Capital Regional Development Authority